Americas Construction: Key Takeaways from Aterio call on US data center development

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We hosted a roundtable discussion with Aterio on US data center and semiconductor market trends as part of our ongoing diligence in tracking US data center construction. Key themes included: (i) a robust multi-year data center capacity outlook supported by projects already under construction, (ii) larger data center campuses and a growing mix of third-party developers, (iii) limited observed impacts on data center construction starts from the recent Texas permitting pause, (v) rising adoption of behind-the-meter generation as developers seek to address power constraints, and (vi) a growing semiconductor project pipeline, with projects under construction rising the past year. Our detailed takeaways follow.

Detailed takeaways

About Aterio

Aterio is a data provider that supplies financial institutions and large corporations with data on data center developments, industrial projects, and energy infrastructure. For data centers, Aterio tracks utility filings, building permits, company announcements, permits, and satellite imagery. This comprehensive approach helps determine whether projects have started, assess their stage of development, identify potential delays, and track whether construction is progressing on schedule.

Tracked capacity and project momentum

- **Tracked capacity has risen sharply in 2026.** Aterio is currently tracking 55 GW of active data center capacity, 83 GW under construction, and 455 GW of announced projects (though a portion of announced projects remain speculative). This compares with January 2026, when Aterio tracked 45 GW of active capacity, 44 GW under construction, and 214 GW of announced projects.
- **Conversion timing.** Announced projects typically take ~1 year to convert into a start after announcement.
- **Probability mix of announced projects.** Of Aterio's announced project pipeline, we calculate ~14% of projects are low probability (<40% likelihood), ~44% are medium probability (50-60% likelihood), and 42% are high probability (>80% likelihood). Aterio's probability rankings are based on a range of project-specific

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factors, including land, power procurement, financing availability, and permitting progress. Projects with secured land, committed power, and identified financing are generally classified as high probability, while projects that consist primarily of announcements with limited evidence of development progress are typically classified as low probability. Aterio also evaluates community opposition and permitting risks, which can impact both project timing and ultimate viability.

Leading indicators

- **New announcements remain strong.** Aterio tracked 113 GW of new data center project announcements in 3Q26, up from 57 GW in 2Q26 and 44 GW in 3Q25. Activity has remained strong into the fourth quarter, with 27 GW of new announcements recorded through October 17.
- **Activation cadence.** Based on Aterio's project-level tracking, the current under-construction pipeline alone supports the activation of ~30 GW of capacity in 2027. For 2028, Aterio sees another ~30 GW of capacity that could be activated from projects currently under construction, as well as the potential for an incremental 18 GW from announced hyperscaler-linked projects that have not yet begun construction. While these figures point to a substantial runway for capacity growth, we note that project timing remains a key source of uncertainty, particularly for projects that have not begun construction.
- **Projects are getting larger.** Data center projects breaking ground continue to increase in scale. The average project starting construction now stands at 131 MW per building, up from 90 MW in 3Q25 and 60 MW in 3Q24. The trend reflects the shift toward larger AI-oriented campuses and suggests that growth in data center capacity is being driven not only by a growing number of projects, but also by a meaningful increase in the size of individual developments.

Who Is building

- **Third-party developers are a majority of the pipeline.** Out of the 83 GW of data center capacity currently under construction in the U.S., 36% is being self-built by hyperscalers, 46% by private third-party developers, 14% by public third-party developers, and 1% remains undisclosed. The data highlights the increasingly important role that third-party developers play in supporting data center growth, with roughly 60% of the construction pipeline being developed by companies other than the hyperscalers themselves.

Regional trends and impact of recent local pauses

- **Top five markets.** Texas, Utah, Virginia, Pennsylvania, and Georgia represent the five largest data center development markets based on announced + in construction capacity. Texas leads by a wide margin (145 GW, 20 GW under construction), followed by Utah (48 GW, 1 GW under construction), Virginia (48 GW, 8 GW under construction), Pennsylvania (30 GW, 3 GW under construction), and Georgia (29 GW, 5 GW under construction). Aterio noted that Virginia has experienced a meaningful slowdown in announced data center capacity during 2026.

- **Texas pause.** Texas has temporarily paused permitting activity while the state conducts an audit of facilities seeking grid connections. According to Aterio, projects that are already under construction and have secured the necessary air permits are largely insulated from the recent actions. More broadly, Aterio noted that site energization and environmental permitting are typically not the final steps in the development process, providing a meaningful buffer within most project schedules. Accordingly, Aterio does not currently expect the recent Texas actions to have a material impact on data center development in the state. Aterio also noted that it has observed at least 4 GW of capacity break ground since the pause was announced and has not seen a meaningful slowdown in construction starts.

Behind the meter

- **Behind the meter power is scaling.** In 2026, Aterio expects ~3 GW of data center capacity to be energized through behind the meter power solutions, representing roughly 15% of total capacity additions. By 2027, Aterio expects behind the meter capacity to account for 41% of newly energized capacity, highlighting the growing importance of alternative power solutions as developers seek to address grid constraints and accelerate project timelines.

Semi project trends

- **Pipeline and construction both growing.** Over the last year, Aterio has tracked 13 new project announcements and 10 construction starts, bringing the pipeline of projects announced but not yet started from 15 projects in October 2025 to 18 projects today. On the in construction side, two projects were completed over the past year, but ongoing construction starts more than offset those completions, increasing the number of projects under construction from 10 to 18 over the last year.

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